

Title : Limitations of Statistical Analysis on Grad Cafe Data

The data from Grad Cafe is anonymously and voluntarily self-reported, which introduces selection bias before any analysis even begins. Applicants choose for themselves whether to post a result, so the dataset reflects the choices of those who participate, not a random sample from all applicants.

Users who are active on forums or who are especially invested in tracking admissions trends are overrepresented, while applicants who never learn about the site, or who simply lose interest after a decision are absent entirely. On top of who chooses to participate, self-reporting bias affects applicants with unusually good news (an acceptance to a top-ranked program) or bad news (a rejection despite strong stats) have more motivation to share their outcome than someone with an unremarkable result.

The data fields are also filled in inconsistently such that GPA and GRE scores are frequently missing, program or university names are typed inconsistently, and status updates are not always corrected after submission, also there's no guarantee that the data is proven by the organization behind Grad Cafe.

These sampling and reporting problems limit what the database can show. For example, Question 11 (average scores for Fall 2026 Master's Computer Science applicants) found an average GPA of 3.77 for Fall 2026 Master's Computer Science applicants, while GRE averages were unavailable because few applicants reported scores.

Question 10 (university with highest applicant count in Fall 2026 PhD Computer Science) reports university/count pairs for Fall 2026 PhD Computer Science records, but those counts represent only rows submitted to Grad Cafe. They may reflect community visibility and reporting habits rather than true applicant volume, so neither result should be treated as representative of the broader applicant population.